

NOTES

**The Sixth Regular Meeting of the
Medford School Committee**

***Monday, November 15, 2021
6:30 PM***

Also presented on Zoom.

<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/97955277949>

6:30 PM Roll Call for Attendance of Members

Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn present; Mea Mustone arriving late

Salute the Flag

Consent Agenda

- Approval of Bills/Payrolls
- Regular School Committee Meeting Minutes, November 8, 2021
- Committee of the Whole Meeting Minutes, November 8, 2021

MOTION to APPROVE: Paul Ruseau, Seconded by Kathy Kreatz
6 in favor. Consent agenda items approved.

Report of Subcommittees

None

Superintendent's Updates and Comments - Dr. Marice Edouard-Vincent, Superintendent

Public Health Update - *As we have noted in the last two School Committee meetings, I will be incorporating updates on the public health and COVID-19 front into my superintendent remarks going forward, but of course Ms. Hines, Mr. Murphy, and other team members are available to answer any questions you might have. Members received our COVID-19 update memo in their email packets and that document is posted on the district website.*

We did see a slight uptick in positivity in last week's surveillance testing after we had dropped to a miniscule 0.37% the week before. Our 1.54% positivity was reflective of both the concerning community-wide numbers and a cluster identified in a program unaffiliated with MPS that our Health Services team immediately notified the Board of Health about last week.

Despite the uptick in positive cases we were very happy to report that we maxed out participation in our MPS students-only COVID-19 vaccination clinic that was held at the Andrews Middle School last Wednesday. Through our partnership with the Board of Health we will be holding a second vaccination clinic for students aged 5 – 11 this

coming Saturday, November 20th from 9am to 1pm at Medford High School. Please be sure to sign up and we'll have additional communication about this in the coming days.

Finally, with respect to public health, today we issued a survey to both staff and parents/caregivers. The survey, which I have referenced in my last few Friday updates to the community, was commissioned by Tufts University, who as you know have partnered with us to have one of the most successful COVID testing programs in the state. The researchers at Tufts are seeking to obtain data related to the barriers that districts faced in getting students back into school and how we can operate on a more equitable basis when it comes to COVID-19 and public health in general. The surveys are voluntary of course but all MPS community members are encouraged to participate. So please check your email for that survey.

Being the month of Thanksgiving, I have notes of gratitude to share with all of you tonight:

A special thank you to the families of the 5-11 year old students who participated in the very successful Covid-19 vaccinations clinic held last Wednesday at the Andrews Middle School. Additionally, we must thank our nursing team and the city's Board of Health team who worked really hard to make this happen. I would also like to thank our CTE/Vocational Health Assisting students who were actively involved in the vaccination clinic. It is so wonderful to know that we are providing our health assisting students with real-life experiences. We are grateful to be able to hold a second clinic this Saturday.

I would like to extend our sincere thanks to all the veterans who took time from their busy schedules to make presentations to our humanities classes on November 10th. We appreciate their service and we were so glad to have been able to welcome them back into our classrooms.

UPCOMING EVENTS!

Saturday, November 20th - Covid 19 Vaccination Clinic for students aged 5-11 years old - 9 AM - 1 PM at Medford High School which is a New location. Also, the Medford BOH has secured an additional 600 vaccines which is fabulous news!

As a result of the increased number of vaccines, we are adding additional appointments to our upcoming vaccine clinic this Saturday. Please go back to the registration portal and sign up for a time. We will also have walk-in appointments available so please don't miss out.

Medical Help Wanted!

We are looking for registered nurses, Nurse Practitioners, PAs, and doctors who are authorized to administer shots to come out and help. Please reach out to Avery Hines our Health Services Director at 781-393-2292 or email at ahines@medford.k12.ma.us if you are interested in volunteering at the vaccination clinic this Saturday.

- Also on Saturday - The Greater Boston Girls on the Run event will be held at Hormel Stadium - 8 AM - 11 AM

On Sunday, November 21st - Mustang Football Coach Curley will be hosting the Alumni Flag Football Game at Hormel - 11 AM

Monday, November 22nd - The Medford Public Schools Wants You! Come join our Mustang Family! The Human Resources Department will be hosting a Job Fair; from 12 noon - 2 PM and again from 3 PM - 5 PM. There are many opportunities throughout our pre K-12 district including: substitute teachers, after school aides, paraprofessionals, Kindergarten Aides, Teachers, and CTE Trade Specific Positions for our Vocational School. We

welcome retirees to join us and the Job Fair will allow for in person interviews with staff. Please plan to bring proper identification and wear a mask. We look forward to meeting you!

Wednesday, November 24th - Mustang Pep Rally (11:30-12:00pm?) outside in the field of dreams-details are being worked out

Thursday, November 25th - Let's Go Mustangs as they take on Malden in Malden, for the Annual Thanksgiving Football Game at 10 AM - tickets can be purchased in the athletic office during Thanksgiving week. Schools are dismissed at 11:30 AM and 12 noon for the Thanksgiving holiday.

Friday, November 26th - No School

Sunday, November 28th - The Mustang Band Parents begin hosting the Annual Christmas Tree & Wreath Sale in the MHS Parking lot from 10 AM - 5 PM

Tuesday, November 30th - MHS Parent Teacher Conference - Night 1 - MHS Gym - 6-8 PM - EL, Science, Math, Wellness & Electives

Thursday, December 2nd - MHS Parent Teacher Conference - Night 2 - MHS Gym - 6-8 PM - ELA, Social Studies, Fine Arts & World Languages.

November is National Native American Heritage Month which acknowledges the unique contributions made by our first Americans for the growth and establishment of the United States. President Biden noted in the annual proclamation, "We honor our Native Americans veterans and service members who have courageously served and continue to serve in our Armed Forces – including the brave Native American Code Talkers in World War I and World War II. This month and every month we honor the precious, strong and enduring cultures and contributions of all Native Americans and recommit ourselves to fulfilling the full promise of our Nation together."

Lastly, since we will not meet again before Thanksgiving, I would like to take this opportunity to wish all of our families an enjoyable holiday. At the same time, Thanksgiving needs to be celebrated safely and I am asking that all students, staff, and families rededicate themselves to our effective COVID prevention measures. It is important that we remain vigilant in our COVID awareness as we go into the Thanksgiving holiday; outside-of-school activities could greatly impact our exposure within school, so please remember to wear a mask, meet with friends and family outdoors when possible, and stay home if ill or recently exposed.

MCAS Alternative Report - Director of Pupil Services Joan Bowen

Mea Mustone joined meeting at 6:54PM

Questions:

Melanie McLaughlin: For the 17 students who participated in the MCAS Alt, is there communication with SEPAC about parent signatures being required on the binder of student work completed throughout the year?

Joan Bowen: I will look into that with SEPAC but parents are required to do the sign off so it has been happening consistently.

Melanie McLaughlin: Are out of district parents doing the same thing?

Joan Bowen: Yes

Report on Professional Development for Administrators - Superintendent Resident Carmen Williams [LINK TO REPORT](#)

Overview of where we are to date. Spent 60 days gathering information and interviewing staff, school committee members, parents and students, reviewing strategic plan, contracts, budgets and student performance data.

Goals for monthly PD meetings for administrators (asst. Principals, principals, directors, asst. Superintendents and superintendent): Define Instructional leadership, building capacity to work with data, building structures across the district, and developing a community of practice.

Improvement of instructional practice: Our leaders need to take on identity as instructional leaders looking at data, building cultures, and creating space for public practice for continuous improvement.

High accountability/High Support: we are asking our leaders to do more than they have done before so we must do more to support them. We still have goals of meeting the needs of students especially in marginalized communities.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Where do we go from here?

Carmen Williams: I am working with them for the rest of the school year. I am collecting data and they are putting together personal data. Hopefully we will have some qualitative data to help us adapt and improve.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: We learned from the discipline policy that the different groups need to be on the same page in forming policy. Do you expect to have results as the year goes on?

Carmen Williams: Decisions need to be made through collaboration; not through silos. Teachers have been bringing data from interviews and through teacher observations.

Melanie McLaughlin: I want to ensure that the data is being collected from all subgroups?

Carmen Williams: Absolutely. We want to mirror best practice and collect data comprehensively.

Engagement Hub Report - Assistant Superintendent of Finance & Operations David Murphy and Director of Family & Community Engagement Megan Fiddler-Carey

Dave Murphy: Last June we presented as part of conversation of usage of ESSER Funding, the establishment of a re-engagement team offering high touch student/family engagement. [LINK TO SLIDES](#)

Underlying purpose of engagement team: in response to exacerbation of challenges for students and families across the district. New piece of the team: family engagement specialists; a diverse team of individuals providing services at all levels.

Megan Fidler-Carey: EL Director, Director of Pupil Services, Director of Counseling and I are meeting once a week to make sure systems are aligned. Looking at the enrollment process (PIC) and working across departments to address confusion in the process. Re-engagement team organizational structure- each one owns a school and becomes part of the school communities. We want to get systems in place for the referral process for the specialists. We know there are systems to be perfected but we need to identify them and get to work.

Dave Murphy: There are subthreads in the HUB and new work that develops as we go. What is challenging and fascinating is that we are looking to build sustainable structures and teams. This work will live in a place where departments are expected to work together. We are also on the ground attempting to provide support in discrete situations every day to improve relationships of particular students with the schools. We built a diverse applicant pool that is working hard to build relationships with students, staff and families. We feel there is a lot of work to do but there is great potential.

Mea Mustone: How does the referral system currently work?

Dave Murphy: We are building the structures as we go. The cross departmental work is so important to identify these cases. We are building flowcharts of who works with the students and when.

Mea Mustone: Is there a ballpark of how many students they see in the elementary schools?

Dave Murphy: The principal can refer the family or students. Each engagement specialist is responsible for two schools.

Mea Mustone: Is there an epidemic where they are overwhelmed and we need more engagement specialists.

Dave Murphy: The pandemic has exacerbated the gaps that had previously existed between families and schools. We need the organization as a whole to work together and not be in silos to meet the needs of students.

Mea Mustone: Is it too early to know what we will need as far as meeting the social emotional needs of students?

Dave Murphy: We need as a district to prioritize engagement. Your question gets to the heart of what we are trying to do. It is an ongoing and continuous process.

Mea Mustone: at the end of this year, will you be able to tell us what we will need going forward as far as staffing. I guess I am a bit unclear what their days look like and how many students they are meeting with.

Megan: In our weekly meetings, we are establishing routines for collecting data on the students they meet with. They need to let the counselors know of the situations as well. Hopefully by the end of the year we will see some trends. Engagement is not just one individual's work - it is meant to be a team approach.

Dave Murphy: there are cases where these specialists have to provide coverage but they are doing it with a lens to build relationships. Our staffing shortages have required all levels of staffing to provide coverage.

Melanie: It sounds like the goals for this year is re engagement around already diminishing relationships?

Dave Murphy: There is also preventative work being done through community involvement.

Melanie McLaughlin: This debt feels heavy on these staff members. How can families engage in the process of identifying the needs of families?

Dave Murphy: There was no family engagement process prior to this hub. Depending on the levels, the work will vary. On the elementary level, there is more direct family contact. Engagement has to be an organizational priority.

Melanie McLaughlin: How do they differ from school adjustment counselors?

Dave Murphy: The lane is more established for adjustment counselors. Generally speaking the idea for the engagement team is for them to be nimble.

Paul Ruseau: Point of information: we did approve the job descriptions for these positions didn't we?

Dave Murphy: Yes. We have individuals with diverse backgrounds to complement each other as a team. There is a lot of work to bring this to fruition.

Melanie McLaughlin: College degree required?

Dave Murphy: We did interview someone without a bachelor's degree but I believe they all do. They have a wide array of duties and I do not want to create barriers to the applicant pool.

Melanie McLaughlin: Can we have some data driven goals and a referral process for students so that the community can visualize it and parents will know who to reach out to. In addition to the other responsibilities, I see Megan Fidler Carey is responsible for transportation and before and after school. How does one person do all this?

Dave Murphy: There is a team working with her. She has a broad portfolio of oversight.

Melanie McLaughlin: Is your job responsible for Special Ed. Transportation as well?

Megan Fidler Carey: No, it is covered by the Spec. Ed. department.

Dave Murphy: Transportation is definitely an area that would be on the top of the list for staffing needs.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Where are the engagement specialists housed in schools?

Megan Fidler Carey: They all have somewhere to sit. The principals have been very welcoming to the specialists and have found a place for all of them.

Paulette Van der Kloot: The word “reengagement specialist” works for adults but how do they introduce themselves to students and families.

Megan Fidler Carey: Family support specialists, outreach specialists and connection specialists.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Helping hand or something like that.

Dave Murphy: Sometimes opening a milk carton is a first step.

Hot Water Heater at MHS - Assistant Superintendent of Finance & Operations David Murphy will provide an update on the awarding of a bid contract for the repairs and/or replacement of a hot water heater at Medford High School.

Provided in the packet this week, was the response to the bidding process for fixing/replacing the hot water heater. Our bids are exemplifying late stage pandemic pricing. The lowest bid came in under \$370K. It is disappointing but it is a necessary repair. Our recommendation is for Enterprise Inc. to receive the work. If you grant the approval, I ask for flexibility for which budget line we use. It will be my hope that revolving funds for services that the hot water heater helps to provide will help defray the costs.

Paul Ruseau: How quickly can they start?

Dave Murphy: Supply chain issues are affecting things but we are hoping to begin in a matter of weeks and complete it in December.

Paul Ruseau: Motion to approve.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Second

Kathy Kreatz: I have in the notes from the B&G that we might be able to get a rebate?

Dave Murphy: We are hopeful we may be able to get a rebate through city hall but are not sure and that is another reason I am seeking flexibility for which line item. Energy efficiency rebates and other types might defray some costs.

Roll Call: Jenny Graham, Kathy Kreatz, Melanie McLaughlin, Mea Mustone, Paul Ruseau, Paulette Van der Kloot, Mayor Breanna Lungo-Koehn: yes 7/0 Paper passes at 7:56 PM

Presentations of the Public - none

Continued Business

- Update on Maintenance of McGlynn Elementary Kindergarten classrooms - requested on November 8, 2021 - David Murphy, Assistant Superintendent of Finance & Operations

Dave Murphy: We are doing water testing at a time when the students are not there and there are challenges as to doing that on weekends. We are hoping to get them in sooner than XMAS vacation.

Breanna Lungo-Koehn: Where is the leak coming from?

Dave Murphy: Testing the water and where it is coming from? The combination of rain and wind is what has caused the damage.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Just to clarify, the students were moved to a different area of the building?

Dave Murphy: The ceiling tiles did not come down when the kids were in there. There may be a temporary patch.

Paulette Van der Kloot: This was one classroom?

Dave Murphy: Three Kindergarten classrooms that are next to each other.

Paulette van Der Kloot: I feel that our rules and regs weren't appropriate when the parent spoke on the floor. The process is difficult because we cannot respond to the immediate concern of a parent. It doesn't speak to the strength of the Admin. Team and it puts us all in a difficult place. Please be more proactive so we can speak more about it. I feel you did all you could right.

Dave Murphy: I don't think my answer tonight or last week will make a parent happy when their kids classroom looks like the pictures they showed. Seeing that it was on the agenda, we should have been more forward with the information.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Are we experiencing anything else right now?

Dave Murphy: Yes, we have a number of infrastructure problems. There are areas that need to be addressed.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Is this a roofing issue?

Dave Murphy: It is a reoccurring infrastructure issue that is presumed to be a design flaw. This does not happen on a weekly basis.

Paulette Van der Kloot: Is this something that can be solved with a new roof?

Dave Murphy: That is something that we need more testing on.

Mea Mustone: Teachers have been emailing for years that this situation has been going on. Kathy and I can speak that this has been reported for a long time. How does the school committee get the physical building concerns addressed before it gets to the point of having a parent show up here?

Dave Murphy: We need a more extensive capital repairs account and we need to build it into a calendar so that you know quarterly or biannually what the needs might be. I have not been a witness to things like this being ignored. I have seen things being addressed with a band aid style of solution that is short lived.

Melanie McLaughlin: Getting up to the podium can be very intimidating and I give the person credit for coming forward. I do believe in Robert's Rules and you can suspend the rules so that issues can be addressed if they are on the floor. We can look into this. Good of the order should be on the first meeting of the month so we can address these items. Perhaps the B&G sub can gather semi annual reports on the buildings.

Paulette Van der Kloot: I do remember that we fixed this problem before and they happen again and again. We had put together at least four years back, an infrastructure report. That document should surface so we can see what already identified

Paul Ruseau: Open Meeting Law prevents us from doing some of the things that Melanie is suggesting through Robert's Rules of Order. Only emergencies.

Melanie McLaughlin: I think the issue was whether that incident was an emergency.

Paulette Van der Kloot: It is asking the administration if children are moved out of the classroom, that you include it in the report of the Superintendent.

Breanna Lungo Koehn: Or have it as a report.

Jenny Graham: Last week we spoke of revising the process of capital planning. We need to be clear about when we are putting band aids on things. Calls to question the competence of us as a district. I understand that sometimes bandaids are the only thing that can be done to allow school to go on. Most of our roofs are at the end of life. I believe our kids deserve to go to school where there are no roof problems. We have to do capital planning in a thoughtful way so we can communicate it through the budgeting process.

New Business

- **Motion for Updated Budget Schedule to Ensure Competitive Hiring Practices**

Whereas Medford Public Schools has historically conducted the annual budgeting process commencing in April and concluding in June

Whereas there is a substantive increase in COVID related funding in FY2022

Whereas hiring practices in many districts are finalized by March/April

Be it Resolved the Medford Public Schools budgeting process commence in January and conclude in March with budget recommendations presented to the City Council in March

- *Submitted by Melanie McLaughlin and Paul Ruseau*

Paulette Van der Kloot: I would like to ask our administrators if this is doable?

Marice Edouard-Vincent: Yes it will be a lot of work to move it up but I do think it will help recruit stronger talent to Medford.

Mayor Breanna Lungo-KoeHN: Is this January date feasible? The city also needs to give a number so I need to get on it myself.

Dave Murphy: The budget process is a continuous one so it goes on all year. I took the motion that the SC wants to have a public discussion on the budgetary needs. As far as with the hiring process, there are variables out of control. We need to decouple the budget process from the hiring process. We do know that we tend to hire an estimated number of people each year. Every year, we know that there are staffing priorities by changing our recruitment strategies to be more competitive. In terms of a more formal public process, I would need direction from the committee as to the route to take.

Jenny Graham: I agree with you. There is no reason that the SC is prohibiting you from hiring the best candidates. Two years ago, we kicked off the budget process with a COW. I am not wed to the way we handle our budget meetings. If we can have a discussion as to how we want the process to work. We can have a COW that sets up a reasonable schedule. There is opportunity for a better process.

Breanna Lungo-KoeHN: Should we amend it to having a COW in January for Admin to bring forth the initial proposal and give the committee something to start from. Understanding the finalization of the budget has variables out of our control. We can identify our priorities but the allocations have different timing. Frontloading as much as possible gets to the essence of the motion.

Melanie McLaughlin: **As is with an amendment that commences with a COW that GET WORDING FROM TAPE**

7/0 motion approved

Reports Requested

- Report on Superintendent's Goals - Tabled on November 8, 2021.

Retabled until December 6, 2021.

Condolences

- The Medford School Committee expresses its sincere condolences to the family of Anthony “Tony” Martin, brother-in-law of School Committee Member Kathy Kreatz.

Next Meeting

- **Monday, December 6, 2021: Regular School Committee Meeting** - Alden Memorial Chambers, Medford City Hall in addition to zoom:
<https://mps02155-org.zoom.us/j/95929381965>

Adjournment: 8:31PM 7/0 approved
Happy Thanksgiving